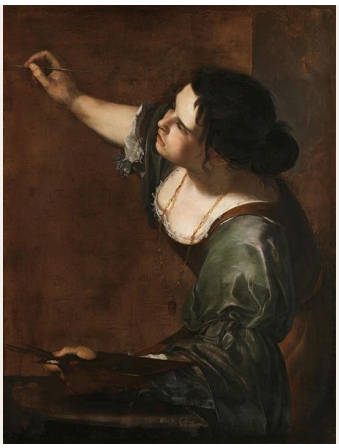
1593–1654 OR LATER

Artemisia Gentileschi: the body at the point of decision

Twenty paintings in which a gesture can carry the weight of a whole story.



A raised hammer, a hand held out, two women suddenly looking in the same direction: Artemisia Gentileschi often locates a narrative at the moment when a body must respond. Action need not mean violence. Her figures paint, play music, wash a child, or hold themselves still while others approach.

This selection follows those different kinds of effort. The Judith paintings deserve close attention, but they do not explain everything around them. An official portrait, a sleeping goddess and a ceiling allegory ask different things of the painter. Comparing them gives a fuller account of her work than treating every heroine as a disguised self-portrait or every gesture as an episode from her life.

Twenty editorial choices, not a complete catalogue or a museum ranking. Reproductions retain their recorded source credits. No current display is promised.

Explore this selection in Artline

Open these twenty works alongside books and events from their period. The lifespan view includes Artemisia Gentileschi, Orazio Gentileschi, Caravaggio and Peter Paul Rubens. These comparisons provide historical context, not claims of direct influence.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/artemisia-gentileschi

The selection · 20

1. Self-Portrait as the Allegory of Painting
   Artemisia Gentileschi · c. 1638–1639
2. Self-Portrait as Saint Catherine of Alexandria
   Artemisia Gentileschi · about 1615-17
3. Judith Beheading Holofernes
   Artemisia Gentileschi · c. 1620
4. Judith and Her Maidservant
   Artemisia Gentileschi · 1613-1614
5. Portrait of a Gonfaloniere
   Artemisia Gentileschi · 1622
6. Esther before Ahasuerus
   Artemisia Gentileschi · 1620s
7. Jael and Sisera
   Artemisia Gentileschi · 1620
8. Allegory of Inclination
   Artemisia Gentileschi · 1615
9. Self-Portrait as a Lute Player
   Artemisia Gentileschi · 1615-1617
10. Conversion of the Magdalene
    Artemisia Gentileschi · 1622-1625
11. Aurora
    Artemisia Gentileschi · 1627
12. Annunciation
    Artemisia Gentileschi · 1630
13. Sleeping Venus
    Artemisia Gentileschi · 1630
14. Clio, the Muse of History
    Artemisia Gentileschi · 1632
15. Corisca and the Satyr
    Artemisia Gentileschi · 1635-1637
16. The Birth of Saint John the Baptist
    Artemisia Gentileschi · 1635
17. Adoration of the Kings
    Artemisia Gentileschi · c. 1636
18. David and Bathsheba
    Artemisia Gentileschi · 1636-1637
19. Lucretia
    Artemisia Gentileschi · 1642
20. Susanna and the Elders
    Artemisia Gentileschi · 1644-48

01 / 20

Self-Portrait as the Allegory of Painting

Artemisia Gentileschi

c. 1638–1639 · Oil on canvas · Royal Collection



Artemisia Gentileschi; WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The pose places professional activity ahead of an easily readable likeness. Artemisia turns toward the work, with one arm reaching and the other supporting the palette. Painting was conventionally personified as a woman; here that convention meets an actual woman practising the art. The claim is made through the difficulty of the pose and the work of the hands.

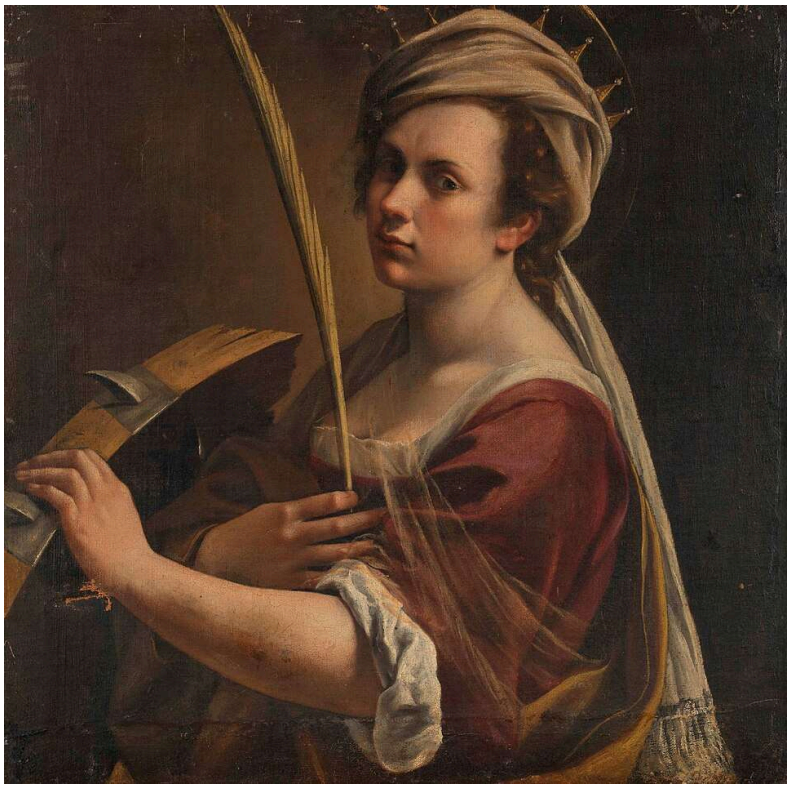
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RCIN 405551

02 / 20

Self-Portrait as Saint Catherine of Alexandria

Artemisia Gentileschi

about 1615-17 · oil on canvas · National Gallery



Artemisia Gentileschi; Source credit: https://www.theguardian.com/artanddesign/2018/jul/06/national-gallery-buys-artemisia-gentileschi-masterpiece-for-36m · Public domain

The wheel identifies Catherine before any account of her martyrdom is needed. Its broken spikes remain beside an apparently composed sitter, while the palm crosses her chest. Artemisia's likeness gives the saint a particular face, but the props establish a role beyond ordinary portraiture. The outward gaze differs sharply from the absorbed worker in the preceding painting.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NG6671

03 / 20

Judith Beheading Holofernes

Artemisia Gentileschi

c. 1620 · Oil on canvas · Uffizi Galleries



Artemisia Gentileschi · Public Domain Mark 1.0 / PD-Art

Judith does not accomplish the killing alone. Her maidservant restrains Holofernes, making the women's combined pressure central to the composition. The extended arms show how much bodily effort the act requires; the bedding leaves its consequences exposed. This is the Uffizi painting of about 1620. The earlier Naples version needs to be examined separately, not used as an interchangeable illustration.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1890 no. 1567

04 / 20

Judith and Her Maidservant

Artemisia Gentileschi

1613-1614 · Palazzo Pitti



Artemisia Gentileschi; WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The danger has moved outside the picture. With the severed head in a basket and the sword against Judith's shoulder, the women turn toward something unseen. Their shared direction of attention gives the pause its force. Nothing approaches within the frame, yet the interrupted departure makes discovery seem possible. The narrative continues through their listening rather than further violence.

Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

Portrait of a Gonfaloniere

Artemisia Gentileschi

1622



Artemisia Gentileschi; WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The sitter's name is uncertain, but his public standing is emphatically presented. Armour, standard and full-length format establish a figure of rank; the white ruff separates the head from the dark clothes. One hand takes support from the table, the other rests at his hip. Authority here depends on a held position, not on a dramatic action.

Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

Esther before Ahasuerus

Artemisia Gentileschi

1620s · Oil on canvas · The Metropolitan Museum of Art



Artemisia Gentileschi · CC0 1.0

Esther approaches a king who could have her killed for entering without permission. Her attendants support her failing body, while Ahasuerus leans forward from his seat. The interval of floor between them matters: it separates the appeal from the answer. The scene's political imbalance becomes legible in two bodily movements, one collapsing and one beginning to respond.

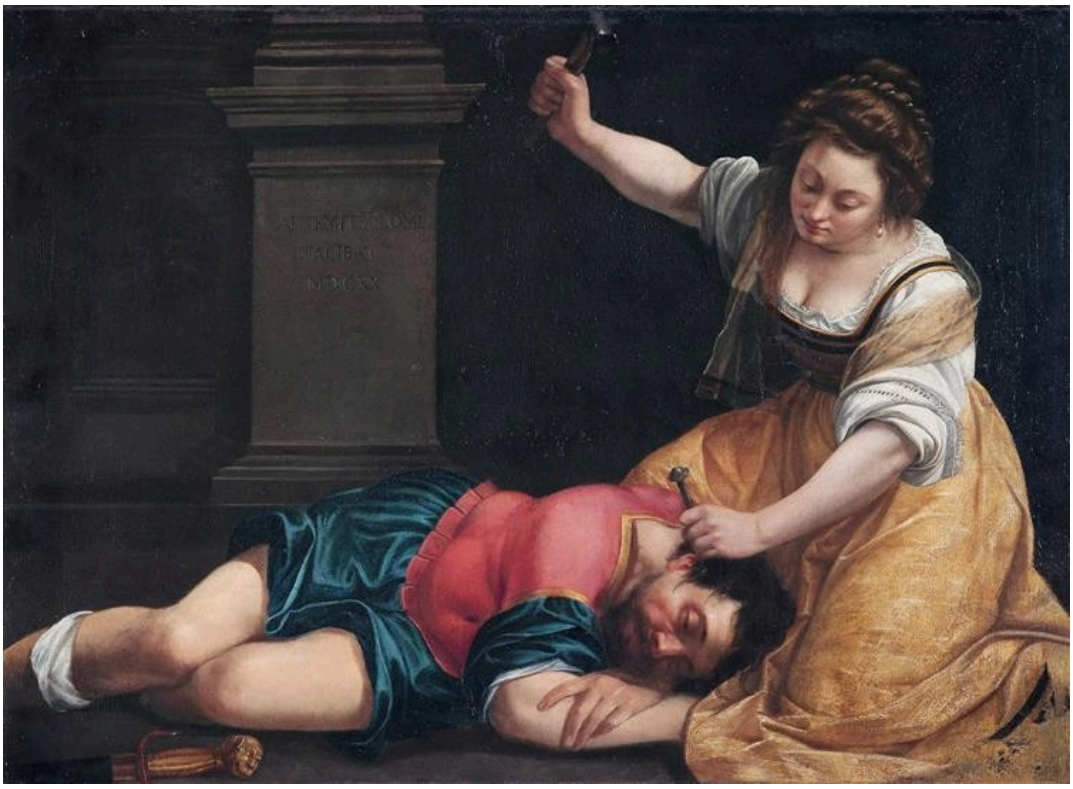
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 69.281

07 / 20

Jael and Sisera

Artemisia Gentileschi

1620 · Museum of Fine Arts, Budapest



Artemisia Gentileschi; WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The hammer is raised, but the blow has not fallen. Jael holds the peg in place while Sisera sleeps across the foreground. Unlike Holofernes, he offers no visible resistance. The concentrated preparation makes the imbalance unmistakable: one figure can choose and act, while the other is unaware that his position has already become fatal.

Object source · Open artwork

08 / 20

Allegory of Inclination

Artemisia Gentileschi

1615 · Casa Buonarroti



Artemisia Gentileschi; WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The compass-bearing figure gives artistic aptitude a human form within Casa Buonarroti's tribute to Michelangelo. Her elevated position belongs to a ceiling scheme, not to an independent easel picture. The cloth now covering her also belongs to the work's history: Volterrano added drapery later. What survives records another painter's intervention as well as Artemisia's original commission.

Object source · Open artwork

09 / 20

Self-Portrait as a Lute Player

Artemisia Gentileschi

1615-1617



Artemisia Gentileschi; WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The instrument determines where the arms can go. Its broad body occupies the foreground, while the neck draws one hand away from the sitter's turned face. Musical accomplishment becomes part of a public self-image, but the painting also sets different surfaces against one another: wood, skin and the open sleeve. The pose gives each its own space.

Object source · Open artwork

10 / 20

Conversion of the Magdalene

Artemisia Gentileschi

1622-1625



Artemisia Gentileschi; WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The lowered head and supporting hand interrupt the display of costly fabric. Conversion has no visible external event here; it is approached through a figure withdrawing from activity. The gold dress and red curtain nevertheless retain their visual attraction. That coexistence keeps the religious subject from becoming a simple division between rejected luxury and inward devotion.

Object source · Open artwork

11 / 20

Aurora

Artemisia Gentileschi

1627



Artemisia Gentileschi; WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Aurora has room to extend her body, a freedom absent from many of the crowded biblical scenes. Raised arms and moving cloth carry her across the dark setting. Dawn takes the form of an approaching figure rather than a detached landscape effect. Compare that outward movement with the Magdalene's folded, supported pose: their different subjects begin in bodily direction.

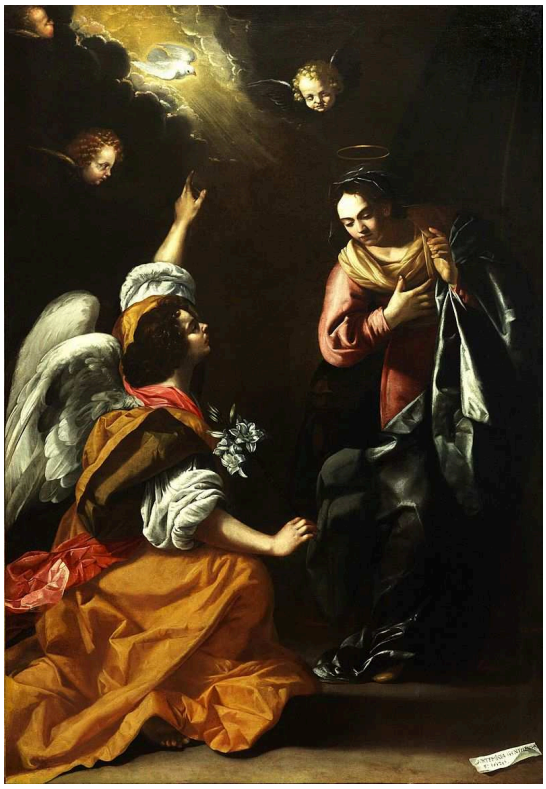
Object source · Open artwork

12 / 20

Annunciation

Artemisia Gentileschi

1630



Artemisia Gentileschi; reproduction via WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The encounter between angel and Mary is joined by a second movement, the light descending from above. Mary's gathered hands answer the angel at the scale of a human exchange, while that light establishes the event's divine origin. The broad spread of drapery near the floor gives the upward-reaching composition a firm lower weight.

Object source · Open artwork

13 / 20

Sleeping Venus

Artemisia Gentileschi

1630



Artemisia Gentileschi; WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Venus does not return the viewer's attention. Her extended body lies against blue bedding while Cupid tends her with a fan. Around this repose, the room opens into a landscape and closes again beneath the curtain. Those contrasting depths keep the reclining figure from becoming a flat display of anatomy; she occupies a setting with its own distances.

Object source · Open artwork

14 / 20

Clio, the Muse of History

Artemisia Gentileschi

1632



Artemisia Gentileschi; WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt label)

An open book records; a trumpet announces. Together they identify Clio's work as preserving and proclaiming the past. Her turned head and hand at the waist give the personification an independent bodily presence. Set beside the Allegory of Painting, she offers another female figure whose subject is intellectual or artistic authority rather than beauty alone.

Object source · Open artwork

15 / 20

Corisca and the Satyr

Artemisia Gentileschi

1635-1637



Artemisia Gentileschi; WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The satyr has caught the wrong thing. Holding Corisca's false hair, he remains crouched while she moves away, her skirt extending the direction of escape. This incident from Guarini's *Il pastor fido* turns on a practical deception. The small object in his hand explains why two bodies that seemed joined by a grasp can suddenly separate.

Object source · Open artwork

16 / 20

The Birth of Saint John the Baptist

Artemisia Gentileschi

1635



Artemisia Gentileschi; reproduction via WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The birth requires work: the child must be supported, washed and passed between hands. Those tasks occupy the foreground, while the older man attends to a writing tablet. Instead of placing routine care outside the sacred event, Artemisia gives it much of the pictorial space. Each figure's action helps make the room intelligible.

Object source · Open artwork

17 / 20

Adoration of the Kings

Artemisia Gentileschi

c. 1636



Artemisia Gentileschi; reproduction via WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Rank is displayed in fabrics and gifts, then qualified by the visitors' lowered bodies. Kneeling and bending direct their attention toward the child Mary holds. The differences in height organise what could otherwise become a crowd of elaborate costumes. Above them, the broken architecture supplies a larger scale against which the act of homage remains concentrated.

Object source · Open artwork

18 / 20

David and Bathsheba

Artemisia Gentileschi

1636-1637



Artemisia Gentileschi; WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The attendants work close to Bathsheba, while David watches from a separate, elevated position. That difference in distance creates two accounts of the same scene: bodily care among the women, observation from outside their immediate activity. David need not dominate the foreground to change its meaning. His distant presence introduces the story's unequal distribution of power.

Object source · Open artwork

19 / 20

Lucretia

Artemisia Gentileschi

1642



Artemisia Gentileschi; WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The dagger points toward the conclusion of Lucretia's story, her suicide following sexual violence. Yet the other hand extends outward and the face turns aside. Those gestures leave the figure less settled than a single emblem of resolve would suggest. In this version, identified by the linked record as 1642, the space before the act remains available for attention.

Object source · Open artwork

20 / 20

Susanna and the Elders

Artemisia Gentileschi

1644-48 · Oil on canvas · The Nivaagaard Collection



Artemisia Gentileschi · Public domain

Susanna's turn away does not create enough distance. The men lean into the same narrow space, and her arms must both protect and support her body. Their threat of a false accusation gives that crowding a narrative purpose. The later Nivaagaard painting makes resistance visible without making escape easy, a distinction that matters more than a generalised label of strength.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 0261NMK

Compare actions, not heroines

Return to a pair of hands: the painter's, the maidservant's, or those washing the newborn. Each performs a different kind of work. The paintings are dispersed across collections; the linked records identify the versions, but do not guarantee current display. For an in-person visit, confirm the exact object with its holding institution.

Further reading

Orazio and Artemisia Gentileschi

Keith Christiansen and Judith W. Mann, with contributors · 2001 · Free museum PDF and online reading

The exhibition catalogue places father and daughter alongside one another, with individual entries and documentary material. Use it to compare their working methods and the changing settings of Artemisia's career.

Artemisia Gentileschi: The Language of Painting

Jesse M. Locker · 2015; paperback 2021 · Publisher page; purchase or library

A study of Artemisia's later career and literary culture. It offers a way to continue from Clio and Corisca without explaining every painting through the events of her youth.

Artist resource · Museum research

Sources checked: 2026-10-12